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California legislature passes two ‘critically important’ bills for Jews

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The California legislature passed two bills Thursday evening that Jewish California considers to be "critically important" for the Jewish community. They now head to the desk of Gavin Newsom, the Democratic governor of California, who has until Sept. 30 to sign or veto them.

AB 395, which would require public schools and agencies to try to avoid scheduling major events, like graduations and public meetings, on holidays such as Rosh Hashanah and Yom Kippur, passed the California State Assembly in a 77-0 vote, with two abstentions, according to Jewish California, formerly known as the Jewish Public Affairs Committee of California (JPAC).

The other bill was AB 1836, which would expand the California Nonprofit Security Grant Program to include offsite events for eligible nonprofits. AB 1836 passed the Assembly in a 78-0 vote with one abstention, per Jewish California.

David Bocarsly, CEO of Jewish California, stated that AB 395 "ends a quiet but persistent form of exclusion—the choice too many Californians have faced between practicing their faith and fully participating in school and civic life."

Regarding AB 1836, Bocarsly said that "our communities don't just gather behind security doors—we gather for religious holidays in the park, we demonstrate and we host public festivals and parades.

"Vulnerable communities should not have to worry about safety when practicing our traditions in the community," he said. "But with hate-motivated violence on the rise, the cost of securing these gatherings has become prohibitive for many organizations, threatening the very community-building that defines us."

Bocarsly thanked Jesse Gabriel, a Democratic state Assembly member and chair of the California Legislative Jewish Caucus, and Jewish California's partners for their work in getting the bills passed.

Another bill Jewish California considers to be important, AB 1763, passed the California State Senate in a 40-0 vote on Tuesday and is also heading to the governor's desk, per Jewish California. AB 1763 would require public schools to excuse absences for religious holidays without requiring written parental requests and principal approvals.

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